HP, HEALING AND DEATH (5E, 2024 RULES) – DESCRIPTION

Hit Points (HP) measure a creature's toughness: the more it has, the harder it is to kill. The maximum is the HP of an unhurt creature. Current HP run from that maximum down to 0. Losing HP has no effect on your capabilities until 0.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. Damage reduces HP; healing restores them, never above the maximum.
2. **Bloodied**: HP at or below half the maximum (no effect in itself).
3. At 0 HP: instant death, or the **Unconscious** condition and Death Saving Throws.
4. **Temporary Hit Points** absorb damage first.
5. Rests restore HP (see the **Rests** sheet).

⚠ Damage:

- **Critical Hit**: roll the damage dice twice (then add modifiers).
- **Multiple targets**: a single damage roll for all. Half: rounded down.
- **Resistance**: damage halved. **Vulnerability**: damage doubled. They don't stack.
- **Order**: adjustments, then Resistance, then Vulnerability. **Immunity**: no damage of that type, or the condition is impossible.

Example: a creature Resistant to everything and Vulnerable to fire, in an aura that removes 5 damage, takes 28 fire damage: $28 - 5 = 23$, half 11, doubled 22.

⚠ Temporary Hit Points:

- They are lost **before** real HP. Example: 5 temporary HP and 7 damage: you lose 5 temporary HP and 2 HP.
- They last until spent or until the end of a **Long Rest**.
- **They don't stack**: keep the old ones or take the new ones (12 or 10, not 22).
- They are neither HP nor healing. At 0 HP, they don't bring you back to consciousness.

Step 1 – Take the damage:

Apply Resistance or Vulnerability, remove temporary HP first, then HP.

Step 2 – Drop to 0 HP:

The creature **dies outright** if:

- It is a monster (the DM may treat it like a character).
- Its HP maximum drops to 0.
- **Massive damage**: the damage remaining after dropping to 0 equals or exceeds its HP maximum.

Otherwise, it becomes **Unconscious**.

Example: maximum 14, current HP 8. It takes 22 damage: 14 remaining, it dies. With 20 damage, 12 remaining: it drops to 0 and stays Unconscious.

Step 3 – Death Saving Throws:

- At the start of each of its turns at 0 HP, roll 1d20 (no ability): **10 or higher** = success, lower = failure.
- **Natural 1**: two failures. **Natural 20**: you regain 1 HP.
- **3 successes**: you are **Stable**. **3 failures**: you die. They need not be consecutive.
- Counters reset as soon as you regain at least 1 HP or become Stable.

Step 4 – Take damage at 0 HP:

Each hit counts as **1 failure**, a Critical Hit counts as **2 failures**. Damage equal to or greater than the HP maximum kills.

Step 5 – Stabilize:

With the **Help** action, succeed on a Wisdom (Medicine) check, **DC 10**. The creature is Stable: 0 HP, still Unconscious, no more death saves. Any damage ends stability. Without healing, it regains 1 HP after 1d4 hours.

Step 6 – Heal, knock out, revive:

- **Healing**: a spell or potion (at least 1 HP) ends the Unconscious condition.
- **Knock out**: with a melee attack that would reduce it to 0, you can leave the creature at 1 HP, Unconscious, on a Short Rest.
- **Death**: a dead creature has no HP. Only magic (*Raise Dead*, *Revivify*) revives it.

⚠ The Incapacitated condition:

- No action, Bonus Action, or Reaction.
- Your **Concentration is broken** and you can't speak.
- If you are Incapacitated when you roll Initiative, you have Disadvantage.

⚠ The Unconscious condition:

- **Inert**: you are Incapacitated and Prone, and you drop what you were holding.
- Speed 0, you can't move.
- Attack rolls against you have **Advantage**.
- You automatically fail Strength and Dexterity saving throws.
- A hit from within 5 feet is a **Critical Hit**.
- You are unaware of your surroundings.

When do you become Unconscious? At 0 HP without dying, when knocked out (1 HP), or while sleeping during a long rest.

⚠ Change from 2014

Bloodied (half HP or fewer) appears as a reference condition. Death-save counters reset as soon as you regain 1 HP. The Unconscious condition now includes Prone. Knocking a creature out places it on a Short Rest.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

Healing a character at 1 HP and letting them drop again ("yo-yo") is effective. A monster that keeps hitting an Unconscious character gives 2 failures per hit (Critical Hit). Fix: the **DM decides what intelligent monsters do**.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

Describe the fall, the fading sounds, the rising cold: the scene becomes stronger than a simple die roll.

Common table questions.

Can a character at 0 HP act?

No: they are Unconscious, so Incapacitated. They only make death saving throws.

What happens when healed at 0 HP?

At 1 HP, the Unconscious condition ends and death-save counters reset. The character stays Prone.

Do temporary HP wake someone up?

No: only healing saves a character at 0 HP.

Does a monster at 0 HP make death saves?

No: it dies, unless the DM treats it like a character.

What damage kills a character at 0 HP?

Damage equal to or greater than their HP maximum, or three failures. Hitting an Unconscious character from within 5 feet is a Critical Hit: 2 failures.

What does a 20 do on death saves?

It restores 1 HP: the character regains consciousness. A 1 counts as 2 failures.

How do I knock out instead of killing?

When a melee attack would reduce the creature to 0, you can leave it at 1 HP, Unconscious, on a Short Rest. When it wakes, the DM decides.

Table rule

Does sleep make you Unconscious?

Yes: while sleeping during a long rest, you have the Unconscious condition.

Can a dead character be resurrected?

Yes, with *Raise Dead* or *Revivify*. The DM may also offer a new character.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Resistance and damage

Resistance can reduce damage to 0 but never below. It applies after other adjustments: on a successful save that still deals damage, Resistance halves it again.

Melee spell attack

Reducing a creature to 0 HP with any melee attack, not only a weapon, can knock it Unconscious.

Concentration and Temporary HP

Temporary HP absorb damage but that damage counts for the concentration save DC (10 Temporary HP and 30 damage: DC 15).

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